# BibleGoAI: AI-Driven Synthesis of Biblical Commentary Using Multi-Stage LLM Pipelines and Retrieval-Augmented Generation

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## Abstract

**BibleGoAI** is a commentary-synthesis pipeline that automatically distills multi-author biblical commentary into concise, source-adherent summary paragraphs (called *Brief Helpful Texts*, or BHTs) from a curated corpus of fourteen commentators spanning four centuries. The pipeline was run once over the full Bible to produce a fixed BHT corpus; each BHT is a short paragraph of roughly 80 words (see Section 5 for per-pipeline distributions), with automated quality scoring and provenance tracking via footnotes linking every claim back to its source commentary. The pipeline combines large language models (LLMs), retrieval-augmented generation (RAG), and semantic similarity scoring across a multi-stage flow: quote extraction, tiered synthesis, constraint-enforced generation with best-of-five selection, and cross-encoder footnote linking. We evaluate the generated corpus across the full 27-book New Testament and the full 39-book Old Testament, comparing a single-pass regular pipeline against a two-stage split pipeline for OT books. The resulting BHTs and their source commentaries are served to end users through BibleGo.org (a web application providing interactive commentary exploration, original-language word study, and full commentator browsing), reaching approximately 100–300 unique users per month. Beyond the engineering contribution, BibleGoAI is also a record of a volunteer-driven faith-community collaboration: commentator curation by ministry leaders, a 28-volunteer digitization effort of Henry Alford's 2,544-page *New Testament for English Readers* commentary, and iterative usability testing with the project's Bible study community.

## 1 Introduction

The study of the Bible has generated one of the largest and most enduring bodies of scholarly commentary in human history. Prominent theologians, from John Calvin in the sixteenth century to Archibald T. Robertson in the twentieth, have produced detailed verse-by-verse analyses that illuminate the linguistic, historical, and theological dimensions of the biblical text. For many Bible studiers, these commentaries are indispensable. Yet the sheer volume of material presents a practical challenge: consulting even a handful of commentators for a single verse requires navigating multiple lengthy texts, synthesizing sometimes divergent perspectives, and extracting the most relevant insights.

BibleGoAI grew out of a simple goal: *help people study the Bible using time-tested commentaries presented in a simple and accessible way*, not only for theological understanding but also as a help to believers in their spiritual growth. The original commentary texts were sourced from StudyLight.org.

Modern advances in natural language processing (NLP) and large language models (LLMs) offer new possibilities for addressing this challenge. Systems based on retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) have demonstrated the ability to ground LLM outputs in authoritative source documents [Lewis et al., 2020], while sentence embeddings [Cer et al., 2018, Reimers and Gurevych, 2019] enable fine-grained semantic comparison between generated and source texts. These capabilities make it feasible to build systems that not only summarize but also *validate* the fidelity of their outputs against the original material.

In this paper, we present **BibleGoAI**, a multi-stage pipeline that transforms curated biblical commentary into concise, source-adherent summary paragraphs called *Brief Helpful Texts* (BHTs). The name reflects the project's core value: bringing the richness of difficult-to-read commentary to the fingertips of Bible readers in an accessible way. The system is designed around three principles:

1. **Fidelity**: BHTs must be grounded in the actual words of trusted commentators, not in the LLM's own knowledge. At least 30% of each BHT's words must originate from source quotes (with a target of 70% and an upper bound of 90%).
2. **Conciseness**: Each BHT is a short paragraph of roughly 80 words and a few sentences (typically 2–4; see Section 5 for per-pipeline distributions), making it practical for quick reference during Bible study.
3. **Traceability**: Every claim in a BHT is linked back to its source commentary via footnotes with similarity scores, enabling readers to verify and explore further.

The pipeline was run once over the entire New Testament (7,957 verses across 27 books) and the full Old Testament (all 39 books), using two pipeline variants: a single-pass regular pipeline for 24 books and a two-stage split pipeline for 20 books (see Section 5 for details). It draws from a curated corpus of 14 commentators spanning four centuries and organized into three tiers of scholarly importance. The NT was publicly launched at a New Year's church conference in December 2023, with the OT following at a Memorial Day church conference in 2024. The resulting BHTs and their source commentaries are served to end users through **BibleGo.org**, a web application that provides interactive commentary exploration, original-language word study via Strong's concordance, and full commentator browsing, serving approximately 100–300 unique users per month with monthly page-view volumes ranging from $\sim$200 to $\sim$2,500 clicks depending on seasonal and community activity.

Our contributions are as follows:

- A multi-stage pipeline for commentary synthesis combining LLM-based quote extraction, tiered prompt engineering, and constraint-enforced generation.
- A composite quality scoring framework that integrates semantic similarity and source fidelity checks.
- An OT-specific two-pipeline design (a single-pass regular pipeline and a two-stage split pipeline) that together covers all 39 Old Testament books, with per-pipeline metrics reported across the generated corpus.
- A user-facing application (BibleGo.org) serving the generated BHTs to a live Bible-study community, demonstrating the practical impact of the system.

**Project context.** BibleGoAI is a volunteer-driven collaboration among Christians, mostly based in the Cleveland, Ohio area, with backgrounds in software engineering, machine learning, and pastoral ministry. The project proceeded through weekly round-table meetings in 2023, a volunteer commentary digitization effort (Henry Alford's 2,544-page *New Testament for English Readers* commentary, digitized by 28 volunteers in 2023, and Robert Govett's 627-page *Commentary on Revelation*, digitized through the same process and completed in 2025), and an intensive April–May 2024 development sprint. The NT was publicly launched at a New Year's church conference in December 2023 and the OT at a Memorial Day church conference in 2024. Several technical decisions were shaped by this community context: the commentator corpus was curated by ministry leaders for theological reliability; usability testing was conducted with members of the project's Bible study community; the NASB 1995 translation was adopted after a request to use the ESV was declined by its publisher's licensing terms; and a sustained cadence of internal demos served as the primary feedback mechanism. These community and process constraints are a meaningful part of what this paper documents.

## 2 Related Work

Our work draws on several intersecting areas of research.

**Abstractive and extractive summarization.** Text summarization has been a long-standing goal of NLP, with approaches ranging from extractive methods that select key sentences [Devlin et al., 2019] to abstractive methods that generate novel text conditioned on source documents [Vaswani et al., 2017]. BibleGoAI employs a hybrid approach: the quote extraction phase is extractive (selecting verbatim passages), while the BHT generation phase is abstractive (synthesizing a coherent paragraph from selected quotes). This hybrid design allows us to leverage the fluency of LLMs while maintaining explicit grounding in source material.

**Retrieval-augmented generation.** RAG systems [Lewis et al., 2020] address the hallucination problem inherent in LLMs by conditioning generation on retrieved documents. Our system applies RAG specifically to multi-verse biblical commentary where per-verse segmentation is impractical, and organizes the retrieved context into a tiered structure across multiple independent commentaries before generation: a design choice that differentiates it from typical RAG systems that retrieve from a single corpus.

**Semantic similarity and sentence embeddings.** The Universal Sentence Encoder [Cer et al., 2018] and Sentence-BERT [Reimers and Gurevych, 2019] provide dense vector representations that enable fine-grained semantic comparison. We use these embeddings for three distinct purposes: retrieval indexing (via FAISS [Johnson et al., 2019]), quality scoring (measuring BHT-to-commentary and BHT-to-verse similarity), and footnote generation (linking BHT sentences to source quotes via cross-encoder scoring).

**AI in digital humanities and biblical studies.** The application of NLP to religious and historical texts is a growing field. Prior work has explored machine translation of biblical texts [NLLB Team, 2022], named entity recognition in historical documents, and topic modeling across theological corpora. BibleGoAI contributes to this space by focusing specifically on *commentary synthesis*: a task that requires not only understanding the source texts but also respecting the scholarly authority and interpretive nuances of individual commentators.

**Existing digital commentary platforms.** Several widely used platforms make public-domain biblical commentary available online, including BibleHub, BlueLetterBible, StudyLight, and Logos Bible Software (commercial). These systems primarily serve as *browsers* over digitized commentary: a reader selects a verse and sees the corresponding excerpts from each commentator, one commentator at a time. They do not attempt to synthesize across commentators, enforce length budgets, or link generated text back to source quotes. BibleGoAI complements rather than replaces these tools: the source corpus itself is drawn from StudyLight, and BibleGo.org links out to full commentator text for readers who want to dive deeper. The contribution here is the *synthesis layer* (producing a short, source-grounded summary that a reader can consume in seconds rather than a multi-commentator reading session), together with the provenance mechanism that keeps each synthesized claim traceable to the underlying commentary.

# 3 System Architecture

BibleGoAI is composed of three major subsystems: (1) a data layer housing the biblical text and commentary corpus, (2) an AI pipeline that generates, scores, and validates BHTs, and (3) a web application that serves the results to end users. Figure 1 provides an overview of the end-to-end architecture.

## 3.1 Data Sources

The system operates on two primary data sources:

**Biblical text.** The New American Standard Bible (NASB, 1995 edition) provides the target verse text for all 66 books of the Bible. Each verse is stored as a JSON record with chapter, verse number, and text content. The NASB was selected for its reputation as a highly literal translation, which aligns well with the commentary corpus.

**Commentary corpus.** The commentary collection comprises 14 curated commentators spanning the 16th through 20th centuries (four centuries of biblical scholarship). For the New Testament, nine commentators form the active corpus: Henry Alford, Jamieson-Fausset-Brown, Albert Barnes, Marvin Vincent, John Calvin, Philip Schaff, Archibald T. Robertson, John Gill, and John Wesley. They are organized into three tiers (Table 1). For the Old Testament, twelve commentators are used: Jamieson-Fausset-Brown, Albert Barnes, John Gill, Keil & Delitzsch, Cyrus I. Scofield, Johann P. Lange, John Calvin, William Kelly, Charles H. Mackintosh, Charles A. Coates, Arthur W. Pink, and Henri L. Rossier, similarly tiered (Table 2). Four commentators (Jamieson-Fausset-Brown, Albert Barnes, John Gill, John Calvin) appear in both the NT and OT corpora, sometimes at different tiers.

All commentaries were curated and vetted by a group of Christians from the Cleveland, Ohio area, ensuring theological reliability and scholarly quality.

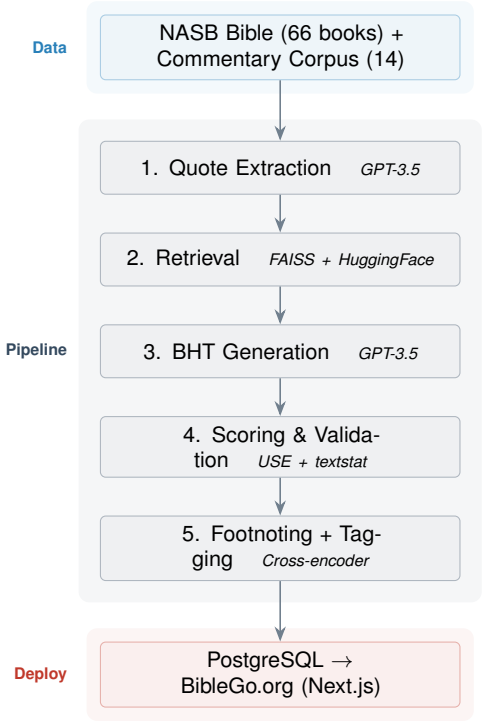


Figure 1: End-to-end system architecture. Commentary and Bible text flow through the five-phase AI pipeline, producing scored BHTs with footnotes that are stored in PostgreSQL and served via BibleGo.org.

### 3.2 Commentator Tiering

The tiering system serves a critical role in the generation process. When synthesizing a BHT, the LLM is instructed to draw *primarily* from Tier 1 commentators, *sparingly* from Tier 2, and *minimally* from Tier 3. This weighted approach ensures that the most trusted and comprehensive commentators dominate the output while allowing supplementary perspectives to enrich the synthesis. Tables 1 and 2 list the active NT and OT commentators with their tier assignments and approximate date ranges.

### 3.3 Prompt Engineering

The pipeline relies on three families of prompts, each iteratively refined through multiple versions and recorded in the project repository: **choicest** (per-commentator quote extraction), **BHT** (single-paragraph synthesis, with both a single-pass *regular* variant and a two-stage *split* variant), and **tag commentary** (verse-level indexing of raw commentary text used during preprocessing). A fourth family, *choicest range*, was developed to extract single-verse quotes from multi-verse commentary but did not reach the production pipeline; verse-range handling was instead addressed through retrieval-augmented generation (Section 4.2) combined with the split pipeline for narrative OT books. The full prompt specifications, including the word-count and quote-proportion constraints used in production, appear in Sections 4.3 and 4.5.

Table 1: Active New Testament commentators and tier assignments. Tier assignments are defined per testament; several commentators (Jamieson-Fausset-Brown, Albert Barnes, John Gill, John Calvin) appear in both the NT and OT corpora and may receive different tiers.

| Commentator | Era | Tier |
|---|---|---|
| Henry Alford | 1810–1871 | 1 |
| Jamieson, Fausset & Brown | 1871 | 1 |
| Marvin R. Vincent | 1834–1922 | 1 |
| Archibald T. Robertson | 1863–1934 | 1 |
| Albert Barnes | 1798–1870 | 2 |
| Philip Schaff | 1819–1893 | 2 |
| John Wesley | 1703–1791 | 3 |
| John Gill | 1697–1771 | 3 |
| John Calvin | 1509–1564 | 3 |

Table 2: Active Old Testament commentators and tier assignments.

| Commentator | Era | Tier |
|---|---|---|
| Keil & Delitzsch | 1807–1890 | 1 |
| Arthur W. Pink | 1886–1952 | 1 |
| Henri L. Rossier | 1835–1928 | 1 |
| Charles A. Coates | 1862–1945 | 1 |
| Charles H. Mackintosh | 1820–1896 | 1 |
| Jamieson, Fausset & Brown | 1871 | 2 |
| Johann P. Lange | 1802–1884 | 2 |
| William Kelly | 1821–1906 | 2 |
| Cyrus I. Scofield | 1843–1921 | 2 |
| Albert Barnes | 1798–1870 | 3 |
| John Gill | 1697–1771 | 3 |
| John Calvin | 1509–1564 | 3 |

### 3.4 Commentary Digitization

Not all commentaries in the corpus were available in digital form. Two major digitization efforts were undertaken by volunteers to expand the commentary corpus:

**Alford's New Testament for English Readers.** Henry Alford's four-volume commentary (1868–1872)

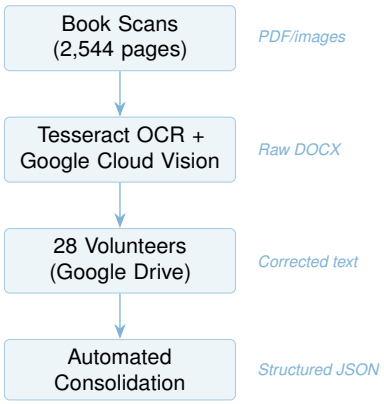


Figure 2: Commentary digitization pipeline. Numerical annotations on the diagram (page count, volunteer count, file count) refer specifically to the Alford project; Govett's *Commentary on Revelation* was digitized through the same three-stage pipeline, and per-project totals for both efforts are reported in the surrounding text.

was digitized from physical book scans totaling 2,544 pages across all 27 New Testament books. The pipeline consisted of three stages: (1) *extraction* via Tesseract OCR and Google Cloud Vision, converting scanned pages to text; (2) *human correction*, in which 28 volunteers spent hundreds of hours reviewing and correcting OCR errors through a coordinated Google Drive spreadsheet; and (3) *automated consolidation*, which detected chapter boundaries, parsed verse-level commentary, performed spell-checking, and produced structured output files. This effort represents a significant scholarly contribution independent of the AI pipeline.

**Govett's Commentary on Revelation.** Robert Govett's commentary on Revelation was digitized through the same volunteer-driven process, spanning 627 pages and producing 274 individual verse commentary files covering all 22 chapters; this digitization effort was completed in 2025, after the BHT generation runs reported in this paper, and is therefore not part of the corpus evaluated here. Both digitization projects followed the same three-stage pipeline, demonstrating its replicability for future commentary digitization.

### 3.5 Original Language Tagging

A separate pipeline was developed to tag every word in the Bible with its corresponding Hebrew or Greek Strong's concordance number. The raw NASB text, with original-language tags provided courtesy of the NASB, was processed through a dedicated parser that produced two outputs:

- **Bible tagged files**: 66 JSON files (one per book), where each English word is linked to its Strong's code (e.g., "beginning" → H7225).
- **Tagged occurrence index**: 14,141 individual Strong's code files containing all 321,621 verse occurrences across the Bible, enabling reverse lookup from any Hebrew or Greek word to every verse where it appears.

A dictionary of 9,333 Hebrew and 5,564 Greek entries was also compiled, providing original-language forms, transliterations, and definitions. This tagging infrastructure powers the Word Donut feature on BibleGo.org (Section 7).

## 4 Methods

The BibleGoAI pipeline transforms raw multi-author biblical commentary into concise, source-adherent summary paragraphs called *Brief Helpful Texts* (BHTs). Because New Testament and Old Testament commentary differ in how they are organized—NT commentary is predominantly verse-by-verse, while OT commentary typically covers multi-verse passages—the pipeline runs two routes that share the same tail stages but diverge at the beginning. Figure 3 shows both routes.

### 4.1 Input Routing: NT and OT

The pipeline branches on input structure at the first stage:

- **NT route.** Commentators write verse-by-verse, so each verse's commentary can be extracted from the corpus directly and handed to the quote-extraction stage unchanged.
- **OT route.** Commentators write on multi-verse passages, so the relevant subset of each passage must first be retrieved for the target verse. Only after retrieval narrows the input does quote extraction run.

After this branching, both routes converge on the same downstream stages. Sections 4.2–4.7 describe those stages in order.

### 4.2 Retrieval (OT only)

When the commentary available for a target verse spans multiple verses (the normal case for OT commentators), the system first retrieves the most verse-relevant chunks before extracting quotes.

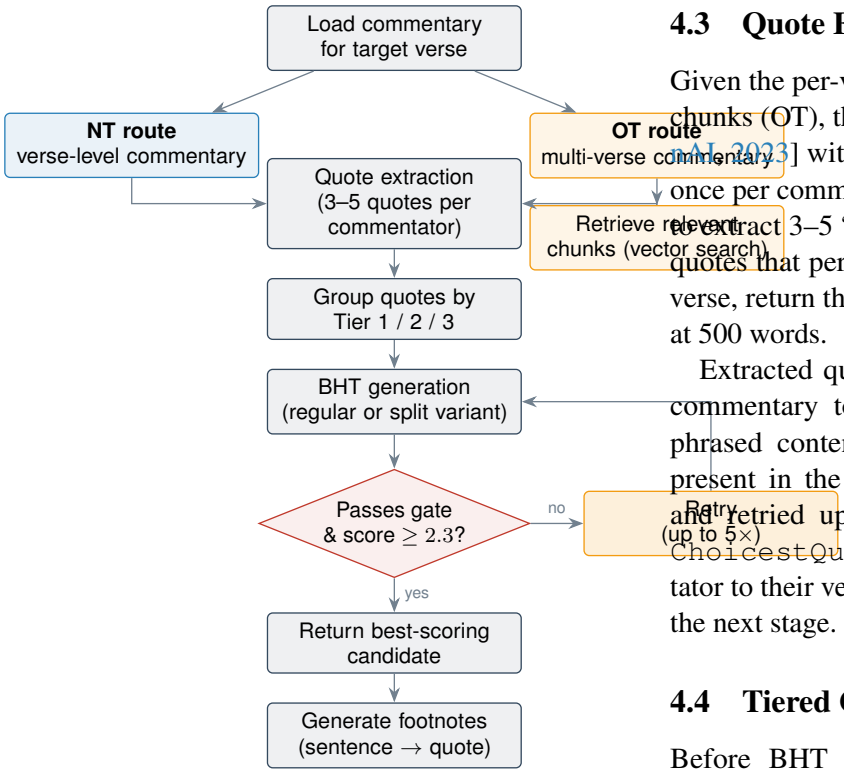


Figure 3: BHT generation flow. The NT and OT routes differ only at the input stage: NT commentary is fed directly to quote extraction, while OT multi-verse commentary is first narrowed to verse-relevant chunks via retrieval. Both routes then share a common tail: tiered grouping, BHT generation with a retry loop, and footnoting.

Commentary text is chunked using LangChain's `CharacterTextSplitter` [Chase, 2022] with a fixed target chunk size. Each chunk is embedded using HuggingFace's `all-mpnet-base-v2` sentence transformer [Song et al., 2020] and indexed with FAISS [Johnson et al., 2019]. At query time, the target Bible verse text is embedded and the top-$k$ most cosine-similar chunks are returned; these retrieved chunks stand in for the full commentary when quote extraction runs (Section 4.3).

Two additional chunking strategies were evaluated during OT development—LangChain's `RecursiveCharacterTextSplitter` (hierarchical splitting on paragraph/sentence/word boundaries) and `SemanticChunker` (embedding-aware, topic-respecting splits)—but were not adopted for the production corpus. An LLM-driven per-verse tagging approach was also tried as an alternative to retrieval and is described in Section 4.9.

## 4.3 Quote Extraction

Given the per-verse commentary (NT) or the retrieved chunks (OT), the system prompts GPT-3.5-turbo [OpenAI, 2023] with the production *choicest prompt* (v2.2) once per commentator. The prompt instructs the model to extract 3–5 "helpful, explanatory, and illuminating" quotes that pertain to the basic words and facts of the verse, return them verbatim, and cap the total response at 500 words.

Extracted quotes are validated against the original commentary to guard against hallucinated or paraphrased content: if any quote contains tokens not present in the source text, the extraction is flagged and retried up to ten times. The resulting object, `ChoicestQuotesForVerse`, maps each commentator to their verified excerpts and becomes the input to the next stage.

## 4.4 Tiered Grouping

Before BHT generation, the extracted quotes are grouped by commentator tier. The NT and OT tier assignments are defined in Section 3 (Tables covering NT and OT tiering). This grouping drives two downstream behaviors: the BHT prompt's instruction to draw primarily from Tier 1 and sparingly from Tier 3, and the tier-weighted scoring formula (Section 4.6).

## 4.5 BHT Generation

The core synthesis step produces a BHT from the tiered quotes. Two generation modes are available:

**Regular generation.** A single call to GPT-3.5-turbo with the *BHT prompt*, which instructs the model to write a short, cohesive paragraph synthesizing the tiered quotes, with explicit per-tier weighting and a target word count. The NT production prompt (v1.3) targets "a concise, informative, and cohesive 50-word paragraph, consisting of 2–3 sentences." The OT production prompt (v0.9) targets a 30–70 word, 1–3 sentence paragraph with at least 50% of words drawn from the provided quotes, and makes the tier-steering rule more explicit:

> *"You will be given the commentary quotes in three "tiers". Please focus mainly on the first-tier commentary, draw sparingly from the second-tier commentary, and only pull from the third-tier commentary when absolutely necessary."*

— excerpt from `bht prompt v0.9` (OT production)

The prompt's stated targets are what is asked of the model; the hard-constraint gate that a candidate must clear to stop the retry loop (Section 4.6) is looser than the prompt targets in both word count and quote proportion, so the prompt biases the model toward the center of the acceptance window.

**Split-BHT variant.** During OT development, single-pass generation produced weaker outputs on long narrative passages where the model struggled to condense many quotes into a coherent paragraph. A two-stage variant was introduced to address this:

1. **Split-A** writes a short synthesis (20–50 words, 1–3 sentences) from the tiered quotes using the Split-A prompt.
2. **Split-B** appends a single additional sentence ($\leq$30 words) to the Split-A output using the Split-B prompt, tightening focus.

The split variant is scored by the same downstream metrics and competes head-to-head with the regular variant; per-variant coverage statistics are reported in Section 5.

**Retry loop.** For both modes, up to 5 generation attempts are made per verse. After each attempt, the candidate is measured against the hard-constraint gate and the continuous score (Section 4.6). If any attempt clears both, the loop terminates early. If no attempt ever clears the gate, all 5 attempts still run and the *best*-scoring candidate (by continuous score, with hard-constraint violations as tiebreakers) is retained regardless of whether it passes—so the served corpus does contain some BHTs that fell below the stop-retry threshold.

## 4.6 Scoring and Validation

Every generated BHT is measured against a hard-constraint gate and a tier-weighted continuous score.

**Hard-constraint gate.**

- **Word count.** Regular and Split-A candidates must fall within 30–80 words (strict range 20–100). Split-B candidates must fall within 15–40 words (strict range 10–50).
- **Quote-word proportion.** 30%–90% of BHT words must originate from the provided quotes, with a target of 70%.
- **Forbidden content.** No commentator names, verse references, or list formatting.

**Commentary-accuracy score.** The primary continuous quality metric is a tier-weighted similarity between the BHT and the source quotes. For each commentator $c$, a per-commentator score $s_c$ is the mean of $(2 \cdot \text{semantic_sim} + 1 \cdot \text{token_sim})$ across every (BHT sentence $\times$ commentator quote) pair, where semantic similarity is computed with the Universal Sentence Encoder [Cer et al., 2018] and token similarity with bag-of-words overlap. Per-commentator scores are then averaged within tier ($t_1$, $t_2$, $t_3$), and combined with tier weights:

$$\text{score} = \frac{3 \cdot t_1 + 2 \cdot t_2 + 1 \cdot t_3}{W}$$

where $W$ is the sum of tier weights (3, 2, 1) restricted to tiers that had data for the verse. A verse with commentary in all three tiers is scored out of $W = 6$; a verse with only Tier 1 data is scored out of $W = 3$. This normalization makes scores comparable across verses with different tier coverage.

**Acceptance-vs-retention semantics.** A score of 2.3 is the retry-loop stopping threshold: if a candidate clears all hard constraints and scores $\geq 2.3$, the retry loop terminates on that attempt. It is not a filter on what enters the corpus—as noted above, the best-scoring candidate is retained even when no attempt reached 2.3. On the BibleGo.org reader, a separate *display-time* cutoff decides whether to surface a BHT to readers: BHTs with score $< 1.0$ are always hidden, and BHTs with score $< 2.0$ are hidden when the verse has fewer than three total commentary sources available. Hidden BHTs are replaced with a "no help text for this verse" message.

**Diagnostic metrics.** In addition to the commentary-accuracy score, the pipeline logs several metrics used for offline corpus analysis but not for BHT selection: readability indices (Flesch Reading Ease, Flesch-Kincaid Grade, Gunning Fog, Automated Readability Index, Dale-Chall; Kincaid et al. 1975, Gunning 1952), tier-contribution percentages, and quote-token proportion. These are recorded per BHT for the aggregate analyses in Section 5.

### 4.7 Footnoting

Once a BHT is selected, provenance links are generated between BHT content and source commentary. Each BHT sentence is compared against every commentator's choicest quotes using a sentence-transformer cross-encoder [Reimers and Gurevych, 2019]. For each sentence, the system records the most similar quote and attaches a footnote containing the commentator, a reference to the quote, the cross-encoder similarity score, and the source location. These footnote annotations are what drive the expandable BHT sentence → source-quote navigation on BibleGo.org.

### 4.8 Example: Matthew 5:9

To make the pipeline concrete, Figure 4 shows a real BHT from the production corpus along with the metadata recorded during generation.

**Matthew 5:9** *("Blessed are the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God.")*

**Generated BHT:**

*"Blessed are the peacemakers, for they not only avoid strife but actively make peace between others. They shall be called sons of God, imitating Jesus who reconciles the separated and brings harmony to those at odds. The peacemakers are not just peaceable, but they work to diffuse peace and reconcile others. May we strive to be like them, transforming into peace-diffusers through the reconciliation and peace we have with God through Jesus Christ."*

**Pipeline metadata:**

- Commentary-accuracy score: **2.54** (above the 2.3 retry-loop threshold)
- Word count: 74 (within the 30–80 gate)
- Quote-word proportion: 48% (within the 30%–90% gate)
- Tier contributions: T1 = 32.7%, T2 = 32.4%, T3 = 34.9% (all three tiers contributed)
- Selected on generation attempt 2 of 5

**Sample footnote link.** BHT sentence 1 ("...actively make peace between others") links to Henry Alford (Tier 1) quote:

> *"They who not only are themselves not men of strife, but make peace between others when at strife."*

Figure 4: A production BHT for Matthew 5:9, with the metadata recorded by the scoring stage and an example footnote linking one BHT sentence back to its source quote. The served BHT on BibleGo.org exposes all four footnote links, one per sentence.

### 4.9 Background: The OT Adaptation

The NT route was built first. Commentators in the NT corpus write verse-by-verse, so quote extraction from the full per-verse commentary worked directly and required no retrieval.

When the team turned to the OT after the public release of NT BHTs, the structural difference of OT commentary broke this assumption: OT commentators typically discuss passages spanning multiple verses, and feeding an entire multi-verse passage to the choicest prompt produced quotes that were off-topic for any specific verse. Two adaptations were explored before the current retrieval-based route stabilized:

1. **Per-verse tagging.** An experiment that asked GPT to segment multi-verse commentary into per-verse sections (via a dedicated "tag commentary" prompt), which could then feed the unmodified NT pipeline. The segmentation proved inconsistent at scale and was not adopted; the tagging code remains in the repository but is not invoked in the production OT run.
2. **Enhanced choicest extraction.** A modified choicest prompt that asked the model to isolate verse-specific quotes from longer passages without segmentation. This also proved unreliable—the model struggled to filter verse-relevant content from long narrative passages.

Retrieval-augmented generation (Section 4.2) resolved the problem: instead of requiring reliable segmentation, the system embeds commentary chunks and retrieves the passages most semantically relevant to each verse. This route produced usable verse-level BHTs without depending on accurate verse-by-verse structure in the source, and it is what unlocked OT coverage at corpus scale.

Because the language model used by the pipeline (GPT-3.5-turbo) is nondeterministic at generation time, re-running the pipeline on the same inputs yields different (but structurally comparable) outputs. The corpus statistics reported in Section 5 reflect a single production run; the hard-constraint gate and scoring ensure quality is reproducible in distribution even when individual outputs vary.

# 5 Evaluation

We evaluate BibleGoAI across multiple dimensions: aggregate quality metrics, pipeline comparison, generation attempt analysis, and commentator tier contribution. All metrics are computed from the full corpus of generated BHTs: 7,957 New Testament verses and the full 39-book Old Testament, which is served via two complementary pipelines: a single-pass *regular* pipeline (24 books, 10,492 verses) and a two-stage *split* pipeline (20 books, 12,653 verses) whose two stages (*split-a* and *split-b*) are concatenated into a single served BHT per verse. The two pipelines overlap at the book level on 5 books (1 Kings, Esther, Habakkuk, Hosea, Micah) but cover different verses within them, so the comparison reported below is corpus-wide over each pipeline's own book set rather than a paired per-verse ablation.

## 5.1 Aggregate Quality Metrics

Table 3 summarizes the key metrics across the NT and OT corpora. The commentary-accuracy score (identical to what is exposed in legacy JSON outputs as `qualityScore`) is a composite tier-weighted similarity between the BHT and its source quotes; quote proportion measures the fraction of BHT words drawn directly from source commentary.

Table 3: Aggregate BHT quality metrics across testaments. Values are mean $\pm$ standard deviation.

| **Metric** | **NT** ($n$=7,957) | **OT** ($n$=10,492) |
|---|---|---|
| Commentary Accuracy | $1.912 \pm 0.348$ | $1.785 \pm 0.282$ |
| Word Count | $84.2 \pm 11.1$ | $62.9 \pm 11.6$ |
| Quote Proportion (%) | $39.6 \pm 7.4$ | $31.8 \pm 6.3$ |
| Verse Accuracy | — | $0.417 \pm 0.147$ |

The NT corpus shows higher average commentary-accuracy scores (1.912 vs. 1.785), with longer BHTs (84 vs. 63 words) and higher quote proportions (39.6% vs. 31.8%). These differences are consistent with the structural contrast between the NT pipeline (verse-by-verse commentary, direct per-verse quote extraction) and the OT pipeline (multi-verse commentary, retrieval-augmented generation) described in Section 4. Verse accuracy was computed only for the OT corpus; see below for discussion.

**A note on NT word count.** The observed NT mean (84.2 words) sits just above the target upper bound (80). The generation loop runs up to five attempts per verse and, if no candidate satisfies the full set of soft constraints (30–80 words, quote-proportion, etc.), the highest-scoring attempt is retained regardless of which constraints it misses. This best-of-five fallback prioritizes commentary quality over strict length compliance, yielding a mean that slightly overshoots the 80-word upper bound; see Section 4 for the full constraint-enforcement protocol.

**Length and sentence-count compliance.** The Conciseness principle (Section 1) targets approximately 80 words and 2–4 sentences per BHT. Table 4 reports realized statistics across the four generation variants in the corpus. NT generation consistently exceeded the 1–3 sentence prompt target (mean 4.2 sentences; 50.6% of NT BHTs are exactly 4 sentences and 83.1% exceed 3 sentences), while all three OT variants stayed within or below it. The split-pipeline served output (*split-a* concatenated with *split-b*) sums to roughly 3.3 sentences per verse on average, comparable to the regular OT pipeline's 2.7. The pattern parallels the word-count finding above: prompt-level length constraints were honored on OT but silently relaxed on NT, where the best-of-five quality-first selection appears to have favored slightly longer, multi-sentence outputs over strict constraint compliance.

Table 4: Realized length and sentence-count statistics per generation variant, against a prompt-level target of approximately 80 words and 2–4 sentences (with an explicit 1–3 sentence soft target in the BHT prompts). Compliance is the percentage of BHTs in that variant landing in 1–3 sentences.

| **Variant** | $n$ | **Words** | **Sent.** | **1–3 sent.** |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| NT v3 | 7,957 | 84.2 | 4.20 | 16.9% |
| OT regular | 10,492 | 61.4 | 2.74 | 94.3% |
| OT split-a | 12,653 | 53.7 | 2.33 | 98.5% |
| OT split-b | 12,653 | 29.5 | 1.00 | 100.0% |

**Verse accuracy (OT only).** The *verse accuracy* metric (cosine similarity between the BHT and the target-verse embedding) was computed only for the OT corpus ($0.417 \pm 0.147$). The metric is not meaningful for the NT pipeline because NT BHTs are produced from per-verse commentary directly tied to the target verse; it exists specifically as a sanity check on the OT RAG pipeline,

which must select the right span across multi-verse commentary.

## 5.2 Pipeline Comparison: Regular vs. Split

Two OT generation pipelines were built, each run once over a different subset of the OT canon:

- **Regular pipeline**: A single-pass generation that produces one BHT per verse from tagged commentary, targeting 30–80 words. Run over 24 OT books (10,492 verses), predominantly wisdom, prophetic, and selected historical books where per-verse commentary coverage was adequate.
- **Split pipeline**: A two-stage generation where *split-a* produces a short factual paragraph and *split-b* adds one enriching sentence; the two outputs are concatenated per-verse into a single BHT, with a combined score computed as the mean of the two stage scores. Run over 20 OT books (12,653 verses), predominantly Pentateuch and historical narrative where verse-range commentary dominates and the split was developed to handle broader context.

**A note on the comparison.** The two pipelines were developed sequentially and run over mostly disjoint book sets. Five books (1 Kings, Esther, Habakkuk, Hosea, Micah) appear in both pipelines' outputs, but inspection reveals that the two pipelines covered *different chapters* of these books with no overlapping verses—the regular-pipeline outputs for these books are experimental partial runs that never reached production. As a result, no paired per-verse head-to-head comparison is possible from the generated corpus; Table 5 reports corpus-wide means over each pipeline's own book set.

The two pipelines produce BHTs with comparable commentary-accuracy means (1.78 vs. 1.82) and near-identical quote-token proportions ($\sim$32%), indicating comparable source-fidelity behavior. The main observable difference is length: split-pipeline BHTs are roughly 35% longer (83 vs. 61 words) because the concatenation of *split-a* and *split-b* yields a two-paragraph output. Because the two pipelines cover different book sets, these corpus-wide means should be read as per-pipeline performance characteristics on the books each was actually run over—not as a controlled ablation.

**Stage-level view (split pipeline only).** Within the split pipeline, *split-a* produces longer, higher-scoring paragraphs on its own (mean commentary-accuracy 1.935, mean word count 53.7) while *split-b* produces shorter, lower-scoring enriching sentences (mean 1.710, mean word count 29.5). These are not alternative strategies (both stages always run together, and the combined served BHT is their concatenation), but the per-stage numbers illustrate the intended asymmetric roles of the two sub-prompts.

Table 5: Pipeline comparison across the OT corpus. Numbers are corpus-wide means over each pipeline's own book set (regular: 24 books; split: 20 books); the two sets overlap at the book level on 5 books but the regular-pipeline outputs for those books are partial experimental runs covering different verses than the split-pipeline outputs, so a paired per-verse comparison is not possible.

| Metric | Regular | Split (combined) |
|---|---|---|
| $n$ (verses) | 10,492 | 12,653 |
| $n$ (books) | 24 | 20 |
| Commentary Accuracy | 1.785 | 1.822 |
| Word Count | 61.4 | 83.2 |
| Quote Prop. (%) | 31.8 | 32.5 |

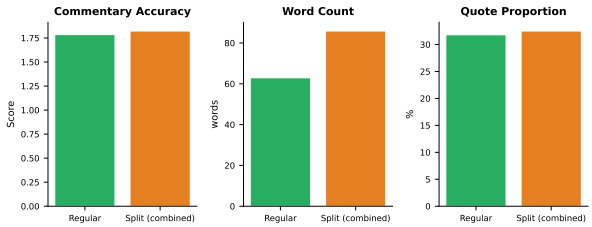


Figure 5: Corpus-wide means for the Regular and Split (combined) OT pipelines across each pipeline's own book set.

## 5.3 Generation Attempt Analysis

The system generates up to five candidate BHTs per verse and selects the highest-scoring attempt. Figure 6 shows the average commentary-accuracy score at each attempt number across all NT and OT runs combined ($n$=43,755 first attempts), which reveals a counter-intuitive pattern: mean scores *decrease* monotonically with attempt index (1.74, 1.70, 1.69, 1.68, 1.67 for attempts 1 through 5). This is not evidence that later generations are worse in absolute terms; rather, it reflects the selection dynamics of the loop: later attempts are only triggered when earlier attempts fail the hard constraint gate (word count, quote proportion, forbid-

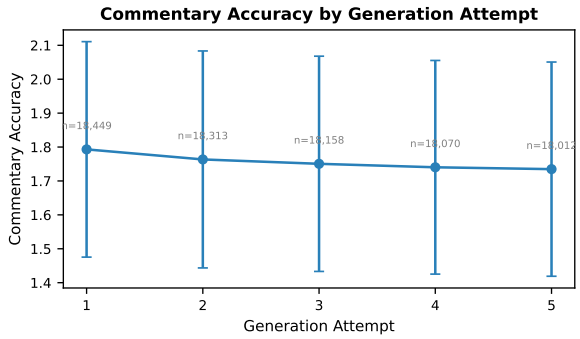


Figure 6: Mean commentary-accuracy score at each generation attempt (1–5). Scores decrease with attempt index because later attempts are only triggered when earlier ones fail the hard constraint gate, so attempts 2–5 are drawn from a harder subset of verses.

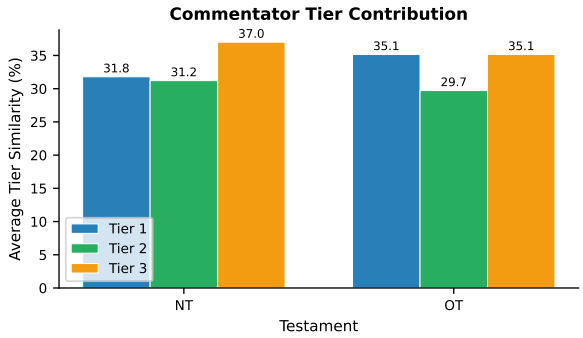


Figure 7: Average commentator-tier contribution to BHT semantic similarity, as a percentage summing to 100% per verse. Tier 3 contributes at or above the level of Tier 1 in both corpora, indicating the tier instruction is not strongly followed in the produced output.

den tokens), so attempts 2–5 are drawn from a harder subset of verses where the generator has already struggled. The best-of-five selection then routinely picks the first-attempt BHT. In the production run, the majority of verses succeeded on attempt 1, and the retry budget primarily functioned as safety capacity for the minority of verses where the first attempt tripped a hard constraint.

## 5.4 Commentator Tier Contribution

Figure 7 shows the distribution of tier-weighted semantic similarity across the three commentator tiers, expressed as the percentage of each tier's contribution to the final BHT's similarity profile (values sum to 100% per verse, averaged across the corpus). Both testaments show a flatter distribution than the prompt's "primarily Tier 1, sparingly Tier 2, minimally Tier 3" instruction would suggest. NT: Tier 1 31.8%, Tier 2 31.2%, Tier 3 37.0%. OT: Tier 1 35.1%, Tier 2 29.7%, Tier 3 35.1%. In both corpora the Tier 3 commentators (Calvin, Gill, Wesley, and others) contribute at or above the level of Tier 1, indicating that the tier instruction is not strongly followed in the produced output. One likely cause is that several Tier 3 commentators produce longer and more thematically broad excerpts than the Tier 1 commentators, yielding higher surface-level similarity scores even when they contribute less content by intent. Reconciling the intent-based tiering with similarity-based measurement is a natural follow-up for future tuning.

## 5.5 Commentary-Accuracy Score Distribution

Figure 8 presents the distribution of commentary-accuracy scores across the NT and OT corpora. Both distributions are approximately Gaussian with a right-skew tail toward higher-scoring verses. For the NT corpus ($n$=7,957), the 5th, 25th, 50th, 75th, and 95th percentiles are 1.32, 1.68, 1.93, 2.14, and 2.46 respectively. The combined OT corpus ($n$=35,798 across regular and split pipelines) runs slightly lower: 1.29, 1.58, 1.80, 2.02, and 2.39 at the same percentiles. The retry-loop stopping threshold is a score of 2.3 (Section 4.6), which sits near the 85th percentile of produced scores. This threshold governs when generation stops, not which BHTs are retained: if no attempt ever clears 2.3, the best-scoring attempt is still kept (best-of-five fallback) to avoid coverage gaps, so a meaningful minority of retained BHTs fall below 2.3. A separate display-time cutoff on BibleGo.org (Section 4.6) hides very-low-scoring BHTs from readers while keeping them in the served corpus.

## 5.6 Human Evaluation

In addition to automated metrics, BHT quality was evaluated through two rounds of structured user testing with members of the project's Bible study community:

- **BHT V2 Quality Test**: Human raters scored NT BHTs on a normalized quality scale. Scores ranged from 50.4 to 94.2 out of 100, with a mean of 67.5. The highest-rated BHT (Romans 6:7, score 94.2) demonstrated strong synthesis of commentary insights, while

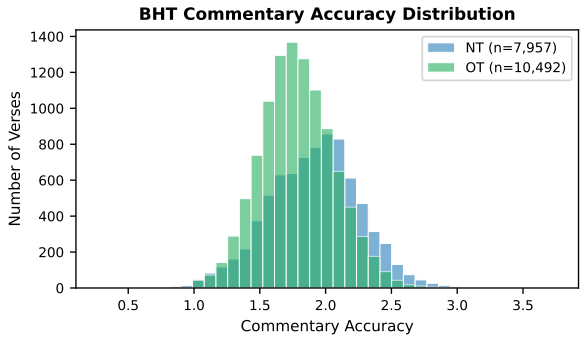


Figure 8: Distribution of commentary-accuracy scores across the NT ($n$=7,957) and OT ($n$=35,798, regular and split pipelines combined) corpora. Both distributions are approximately Gaussian with a right-skew tail; the nominal acceptance threshold (2.3) sits near the 85th percentile of produced scores.

lower-scoring BHTs guided subsequent prompt refinements.

- **OT BHT V1 Quality Test**: A separate round evaluated the first generation of OT BHTs, providing feedback that informed the comparison of RAG versus tagging strategies.

Table 6 presents the human quality scores from the BHT V2 evaluation. Note that these are a separate metric from the automated *commentary-accuracy* score discussed above: raters scored each BHT on a normalized 0–100 quality scale.

Table 6: Human evaluation scores (BHT V2 Quality Test). Human-assigned 0–100 quality ratings; distinct from the automated commentary-accuracy score in Table 3.

| Verse | Human Score |
|---|---|
| Romans 6:7 | 94.2 |
| John 5:22 | 80.1 |
| Ephesians 1:22 | 77.3 |
| Ephesians 6:13 | 65.5 |
| Galatians 5:22 | 62.7 |
| John 10:27 | 57.0 |
| Romans 6:21 | 54.1 |
| Revelation 3:3 | 50.4 |
| **Mean** | **67.7** |

These human scores, combined with the automated quality metrics, provided a feedback loop that drove iterative prompt refinement: most notably the May 2024 prompt updates that shifted the choicest extraction focus from "striking and enlightening" to "helpful, explanatory, and illuminating" quotes targeting basic words and facts in each verse.

## 6 Discussion

**Strengths.** The multi-stage pipeline design offers several advantages over end-to-end generation, though we note upfront that the quantitative comparison against a modern zero-shot baseline remains future work (see Limitations below). By extracting verbatim quotes before synthesis, the system creates an auditable intermediate representation that can be inspected and validated independently of the final BHT. The tiered commentator system ensures that the most authoritative voices dominate the output, while the constraint enforcement (word count, quote proportion, forbidden phrases) prevents many common failure modes of unconstrained LLM generation.

The iterative prompt refinement process (spanning multiple versions across three prompt families that shipped in the production run) proved essential. Early prompt versions produced BHTs that frequently exceeded word limits, included commentator names, or adopted list formatting. Later versions largely eliminated these issues, demonstrating the value of systematic prompt engineering with quantitative feedback loops.

**Limitations.** Several limitations warrant discussion. First, the entire BHT corpus was generated using GPT-3.5-turbo, which was among the most capable generally available models at the time of development; no regeneration has been performed on newer models because the pipeline was run once to produce the served corpus, and that one-time run's output quality remained acceptable while inference cost for newer models was substantially higher at the time. A full-scale regeneration and re-evaluation on more recent models remains future work. Second, the quality scoring framework, while multi-dimensional, relies heavily on embedding-based similarity, which may not capture all aspects of theological accuracy or interpretive nuance. Third, the quote-proportion constraint (30–90% of BHT words drawn from source quotes, with a 70% target), while ensuring grounding, can sometimes produce BHTs that read as stitched-together phrases rather than naturally flowing prose. Fourth, we do not yet include a zero-shot LLM baseline (e.g., prompting a frontier model directly

with all available commentary for a verse and asking it to summarize), so the marginal value of the multi-stage pipeline over modern end-to-end generation has not been quantitatively isolated.

**Source adherence vs. fluency.** A fundamental tension exists between source adherence and fluency of the generated text. Higher quote proportions ensure adherence but can reduce coherence; lower proportions allow smoother prose but risk introducing LLM-generated content that may not reflect the commentators' actual positions. Our operating range of 30–90% with a 70% target represents a pragmatic balance, validated through iterative testing and user feedback; the observed corpus-level means (39.6% for NT, 31.8% for OT; see Table 3) satisfy the 30% floor and stay well below the 90% ceiling, but consistently fall short of the 70% target. In practice, produced BHTs paraphrase more than the target specifies; the gap between target and observed behavior is a known limitation and a natural candidate for follow-up tuning.

**Prompt engineering insights.** The evolution of prompts yielded several practical insights: (1) explicit negative constraints ("do not mention commentators") were more effective than positive-only instructions; (2) specifying exact word count ranges reduced variance more than vague length instructions; (3) the tiering language ("primarily," "sparingly," "minimally") meaningfully influenced the tier distribution in generated outputs; and (4) requesting numbered quotes in the extraction phase significantly improved downstream validation.

## 7 Deployment: BibleGo.org

The BHTs generated by BibleGoAI are served to end users through **BibleGo.org**, a web application built with Next.js [Vercel, 2023], React, and TypeScript, backed by a PostgreSQL database and hosted on Vercel. The platform reaches approximately 100–300 unique users per month, with monthly page-view volumes ranging from ∼200 to ∼2,500 depending on seasonal and community activity. This section briefly describes the served interface so that the BHTs evaluated in Section 5 can be situated in their delivered form; full deployment details are out of scope for this paper.

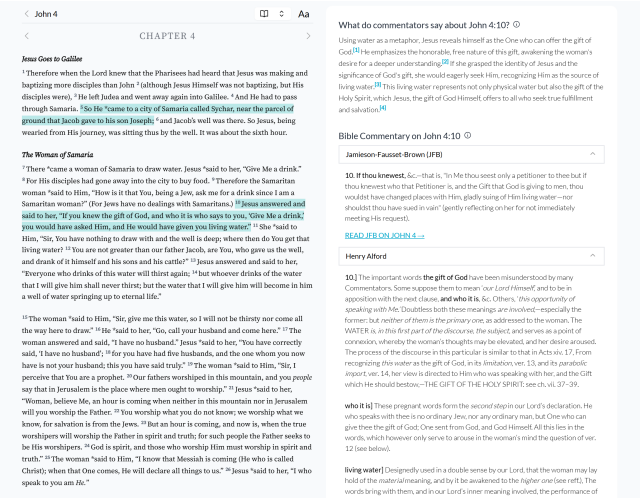


Figure 9: The BibleGo.org desktop reading interface. The two-column layout presents the NASB Bible text with inline original-language tags (left) alongside the BHT commentary panel (right), in which footnotes link each sentence back to its source commentator.

**Reading interface.** The main reading interface (Figure 9) presents a two-column layout: the NASB Bible text with inline original-language tags on the left, and a commentary panel on the right. When a user selects a verse, the corresponding BHT is displayed along with footnotes that link each sentence to its source commentary; users can expand individual footnotes to view the original quotes, the commentator attribution, and a similarity score. Each commentator's full excerpt is also available as a separate card, enabling side-by-side comparison of perspectives. On mobile the commentary panel appears as a slide-up drawer (Figure 10). A separate full-commentary mode is also available, in which readers can browse the complete chapter-level text from any individual commentator.

**Word study.** BibleGo.org also includes an interactive word-study feature, the *Word Donut*, powered by Strong's concordance data built from the original-language tagging pipeline (Section 3). A user can select any word in the Bible text to view its original Greek or Hebrew form, transliteration, and definition; an interactive doughnut chart then visualizes how the NASB translators rendered that word across all of its biblical occurrences (Figure 11). The same widget is available on mobile via the reading drawer.

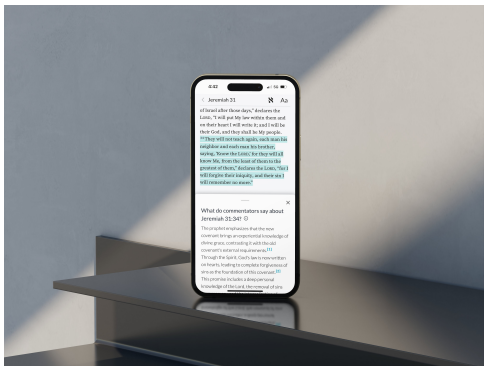

Figure 10: The BibleGo.org mobile experience with the BHT commentary drawer. Footnotes (numbered markers) link each sentence back to its source commentator, allowing users to trace every claim to the original commentary.

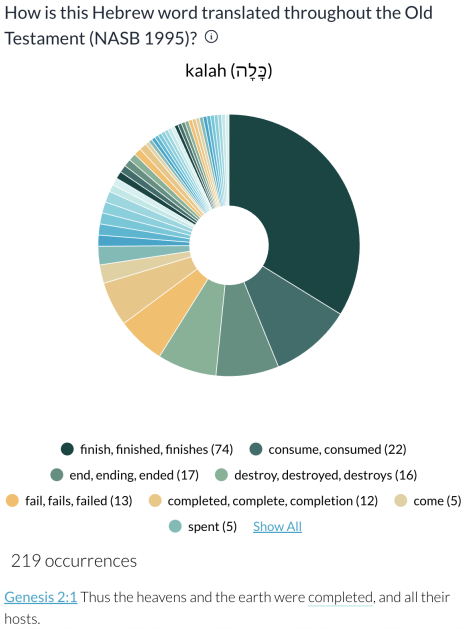


Figure 11: The Word Donut visualization for the Hebrew word *kalah*, showing how it is rendered across 219 Old Testament occurrences. Segments represent distinct English renderings (e.g., "finish" 74×, "consume" 22×), enabling readers to explore semantic range without knowledge of the original language.

**User experience and data flow.** The application provides dark mode, adjustable font sizes, mobile-responsive layout, deep linking via URL parameters (e.g., `/read?v=Matthew.1.1`), and an in-app feedback system; the UI underwent four rounds of dedicated usability testing, including tests focused specifically on the drawer navigation and the Word Donut. Pre-generated BHTs from the BibleGoAI pipeline are loaded into a PostgreSQL database and served by the Next.js application through server-side API routes; Bible text with Strong's tags is served from static JSON files, while Strong's concordance entries are queried from the database.

## 8 Conclusion and Future Work

We have presented BibleGoAI, a multi-stage pipeline for synthesizing concise, source-adherent summaries of biblical commentary using large language models, retrieval-augmented generation, and semantic similarity scoring. The pipeline was run once over a curated corpus of 14 commentators spanning four centuries, producing Brief Helpful Texts (BHTs) of roughly 80 words each (see Section 5 for per-pipeline distributions) that are grounded in source material, quality-scored across multiple dimensions, and traceable via automated footnotes. The resulting BHTs and their source commentaries are served through BibleGo.org, reaching approximately 100–300 unique users per month at the time of writing.

**Future work.** Several directions remain for future development:

- **Regeneration with stronger models**: Re-running the pipeline against the same source corpus using more recent frontier LLMs to measure how much of the residual quality gap is attributable to the GPT-3.5-era generator versus the pipeline design itself.
- **Live admin-driven regeneration**: Deploying the pipeline as a live service so that administrators can regenerate individual BHTs (or whole books) on demand as commentators are added, prompts are refined, or source-text corrections land, rather than treating BHT production as a one-shot offline process.
- **Publishing the digitized commentaries**: Releasing the digitized texts of Henry Alford's *New Testament for English Readers* and Robert Govett's *Commentary on Revelation* as standalone open resources, independent of the BHT pipeline, so the human digitization effort is reusable beyond this project.

- **Additional commentators**: Continuing to expand the curated corpus with further historical and contemporary commentators; Govett's commentary on Revelation was completed and added to the digitized corpus in 2025 following the work reported here, and similar additions are under consideration.
- **Enhanced original-language tools**: Considered for future iterations, expanding word-study features beyond Strong's concordance to include Hebrew morphology, cross-references, and parallel passage analysis.

**Lessons for similar projects.** Four patterns from this work generalize beyond biblical commentary. First, an extractive intermediate representation (the *choicest quotes* phase) proved decisive: it gives every downstream stage an auditable artifact and makes source fidelity checkable without re-reading every commentary. Second, a best-of-$N$ loop against a hard constraint gate is a low-cost way to get acceptable coverage from an imperfect generator, at the price of a small fraction of retained outputs that miss the nominal quality threshold; the attempt-level analysis in Section 5 shows this tradeoff concretely. Third, a volunteer-driven curation and digitization effort can substantially expand a domain's source corpus beyond what any individual team could assemble, but only when paired with a structured consolidation pipeline that merges human correction back into machine-readable form; the same digitization pipeline served both the Alford and Govett efforts, demonstrating its replicability across projects. Fourth, automated footnote generation against the source corpus proved decisive for credibility and verifiability. Beyond the engineering value of similarity scoring, the visible per-claim footnote chain in the served BHTs gave readers a tangible verification path: the difference between "trust the LLM" and "click to read where this came from." For domains where source-claim grounding determines whether users will trust the system at all (medical, legal, theological), this is not optional polish; it is the feature that makes the system usable. Domains with similar characteristics (specialized corpora, community stewardship, and a need for claim-level traceability) may find the overall pattern reusable.

## Acknowledgments

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